

Session 29: 10 Generations From Adam to Noah

Key Takeaways

- The genealogy of Genesis 5 shares some similarities with other ancient Near Eastern genealogies, but the way that this one differs makes a profound theological statement.
- Enoch is a hero in the biblical value system—not a great king or civilization builder but one who walks with God. The naming of Noah in Genesis 5 brings many of the preceding themes together as the story moves forward.

Ten Generations From Adam to Noah

After the humans are exiled from Eden, and after the drama that splits Adam and Eve’s family into two lines, the narrative reboots and begins again. This time, the genealogy follows the line of Seth, with Cain’s line having been concluded with Lemek and his sons. This genealogy has a highly schematic form, which makes the three narrative inserts stick out.

Generation	Verse	Person	Age
1	5:1-2, 3a	Narrative Insert	930yrs
	5:3-5	Adam	
2	5:6-8	Seth	912yrs
3	5:9-11	Enosh	905yrs
4	5:12-14	Cainan	910yrs
5	5:15-17	Mahalalel	895yrs
6	5:18-20	Yared	962yrs
7	5:21-24	Enoch	365yrs
Ten Generations from Adam to Noah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

Generation	Verse	Person	Age
	5:22, 24	Narrative Insert	
8	5:25-27	Methuselah	969yrs
9	5:28-31	Lemek	777yrs
	5:29	Narrative Insert	
10	5:32	Noah	TBD...
Ten Generations from Adam to Noah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

Ten Generations From Adam to Noah: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 5:1-32

This genealogy lists 10 generations from Adam to Noah, each one given in an identical literary form:

*and __ **lived** __ years, and he caused the birth of [son's name]. and __ **lived** __ years after he caused the birth of [son's name], and he caused the birth of sons and daughters, and all the days of __ **were** __ years, and he died.*

There are three figures whose genealogical entry deviates from this form, and at precisely these three points, we find narrative inserts that highlight significant themes in Genesis. Pay special attention to Adam, Enoch, and Lemech/Noah.

Prologue

¹ This is the scroll of the generations of **Adam** ;
 In the day when Elohim created **humanity** ,
 he made him as the likeness of Elohim,
 male and female he created them,
 and he blessed them
 and he named them **'human'**
 in the day when they were created.

10 Generations

Adam

³ And Adam had lived one hundred and thirty years,

and he caused the birth of one

in his own likeness,
according to his image,
and named him Seth.

⁴ And the days of Adam after he caused the birth of Seth were eight hundred years,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

⁵ And all the days that Adam lived were nine hundred and thirty years,
and he died.

Seth

⁶ And Seth lived one hundred and five years,
and he caused the birth of Enosh.

⁷ And Seth lived eight hundred and seven years after he caused the birth of Enosh,
and he he caused the birth of sons and daughters,

⁸ and all the days of Seth were nine hundred and twelve years,
and he died.

Enosh

⁹ And Enosh lived ninety years,
and he caused the birth of Cainan.

¹⁰ And Enosh lived eight hundred and fifteen years after he caused the birth of Cainan,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

¹¹ And all the days of Enosh were nine hundred and five years,
and he died.

Cainan

¹² And Cainan lived seventy years,
and he caused the birth of Mahalalel.

¹³ And Cainan lived eight hundred and forty years after he he caused the birth of Mahalalel,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

¹⁴ And all the days of Cainan were nine hundred and ten years,
and he died.

Mahalalel

¹⁵ And Mahalalel lived sixty-five years,
and he caused the birth of Jared.

¹⁶ And Mahalalel lived eight hundred and thirty years after he became the father of Jared,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

¹⁷ And all the days of Mahalalel were eight hundred and ninety-five years,
and he died.

Yared

¹⁸ And Yared lived one hundred and sixty-two years,
and he caused the birth of Enoch.

¹⁹ And Yared lived eight hundred years after he became the father of Enoch,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

²⁰ And all the days of Yared were nine hundred and sixty-two years,
and he died.

Enoch

²¹ And Enoch lived sixty-five years,
and he caused the birth of Methuselah,

²² and Enoch **walked with God three hundred years**

after he became the father of Methuselah,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters,

²³ and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years,

²⁴ **and Enoch walked with God ;**

and he was not, for God took him .

Methuselah

²⁵ And Methuselah lived one hundred and eighty-seven years,
and he became the father of Lemek,

²⁶ and Methuselah lived seven hundred and eighty-two years after he became the father of Lemek,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

²⁷ And all the days of Methuselah were nine hundred and sixty-nine years,
and he died.

Lemek

²⁸ And Lemek lived one hundred and eighty-two years,
and he caused the birth of a son,

²⁹ **and he called his name "Noah," saying,**

"This one will give us rest from our work

and from the toil of our hands from the ground

which the Lord has cursed."

²⁰ And Lemek lived five hundred and ninety-five years after he became the father of Noah,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters,

³¹ and all the days of Lemek were seven hundred and seventy-seven years,
and he died.

Noah

³² And Noah was five hundred years old,
and Noah he caused the birth of Shem, Ham, and Japheth ...

Genesis 5:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

The Genealogy of Genesis 5 From an Ancient Near Eastern Perspective

It seems very probable that the author of Genesis has drawn upon ancient Mesopotamian traditions of the generations of humanity before the flood and strategically adapted them for his own theological and communication purposes.

There was a widespread belief in ancient Assyria and Babylon that the most ancient roots of civilization and kingship came from the gods from before the time of the flood. These traditions are expressed in a series of ancient texts called *The Sumerian King Lists*, which are found in multiple versions (see Jacobsen, Thorkild, *The Sumerian King Lists*, and VanderKam, James, *Enoch and the Growth of an Apocalyptic Tradition*).

The Sumerian King List Compared with Genesis 5

The Sumerian King Lists	Genesis 5
There are 10 kings from the creation of kingship to the flood and right after the flood.	There are 10 generations from Adam to the flood of Noah, who lives after the flood.
The first king, Alulim, is appointed by the oldest gods.	Adam and Eve (= ‘adam, “humanity”) is appointed as the royal image of God to rule all creation.
The final king is chosen to survive the flood.	Noah, the tenth, is chosen to survive the flood.
The 10 kings rule for hyperbolically long periods of time (two versions are based on WB 62 and WB 444; see Jacobsen, <i>The Sumerian King Lists</i>, 70-77). Alulim - 67,200 or 28,800 Alalgar - 72,000 or 36,000 Kidunnu - 72,000 or 43,200 Alimma - 21,600 or 28,800 Dumuzi - 21,600 or 36,000 Enmenluanna - 21,600 or 28,800 Enmeduranki - 36,000 or 21,000 Enmeduranna - 72,000 or 18,000 Ubartutu - 28,000 or [NA] Ziusudra - 36,000 or [NA]	The 10 patriarchs live for long periods of time Adam - 930 years Seth - 912 years Enosh - 905 years Qenan - 910 years Mahalalel - 895 years Yared - 962 years Enoch - 365 years Methushelah - 969 years Lemek - 777 years Noah - 950 years
<i>Similarities Between the Sumerian King List and Genesis 5.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

The Sumerian King Lists	Genesis 5
The seventh king, Enmeduranki, is brought up into the divine assembly and has a unique role among the gods.	The seventh patriarch, Enoch, does not die but is translated to God’s realm because of his special relationship with God.
<i>Similarities Between the Sumerian King List and Genesis 5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).</i>	

This last connection between Enoch and Enmeduranki is important and has been the focus of much scholarship (see VanderKam, James, *Enoch and the Growth of an Apocalyptic Tradition*).

Enmeduranki is the seventh king who ruled in the ancient city of Sippar, and whose patron deity was Shamash, the sun deity. Enoch is the seventh generation listed in Genesis 5, and his curiously shorter life corresponds exactly to the days of the solar year: 365.

Enmeduranki passed on traditions of divination and techniques for discerning the will of the gods. He received this ability because of a special experience he is said to have had.

“Shamash [the sun-god] in Ebabbarra [appointed] Enmeduranki [king of Sippar], the beloved of Anu, Enlil, [and Ea]. Shamash and Adad [the storm-god] brought him into their assembly, they honored him, and they set him on a large throne of gold ... they gave him the tablet of the gods ... a secret of heaven and the underworld ... He is the learned sage, who guards the secrets of the great gods ...”

Lambert, W. G. (1967). *"Enmeduranki and Related Matters"*. *Journal of Cuneiform Studies*, Vol. 21. The University of Chicago Press.

This text from the 12th century B.C. goes on to state that Enmeduranki was the founder of the guild of Mesopotamian diviners, who were able discern the will of the gods. He was elevated to the divine realm and given secret knowledge of the gods, which was inscribed in texts that he then passes onto his descendants in Nippur, Sippar, and Babylon.

In the same period of the 12th century, Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, makes a public claim that he is the descendant of Enmeduranki.

“[I am] distant heir of kingship, of seed preserved from before the flood, offspring of Enmeduranki, king of Sippar ... who sat in the presence of Shamash and Adad, the divine judges ...”

Lambert, W. G. (1967). *"Enmeduranki and Related Matters"*. *Journal of Cuneiform Studies*, Vol. 21. The University of Chicago Press.

These traditions have a clear similarity to the traditions of Enoch, the seventh from Adam, who has a close association with God and is “taken” into the divine realm of eternal life. However, the role of Enoch in the story of Genesis has been strategically adapted to the theological message of the author, who is making a very different set of claims, ones that outshine the claim of Nebuchadnezzar!

While these traditions are hinted at in [Genesis 5:21-24](#), it is clear that there was also a larger set of ancient traditions about Enoch as the master sage elevated to the divine realm, where he learned divine mysteries and revealed them to his son Methuselah. These traditions are found in the texts compiled together in 1 Enoch and 2 Enoch.

“Every indicator points to the conclusion that the author of [1 Enoch chs. 72-82] has fixed in writing a very old state ... of Enochic lore ... By presenting the seventh biblical patriarch as the person to whom God chose to reveal astronomical information, the writer ranks Enoch alongside other culture heroes from the various peoples of the ancient world. There was a widespread belief in the ancient Near East, and in the classical world, that knowledge about the sun, moon, and stars had been divulged to special individuals at the dawn of history. And here Enoch is set among their ranks.”

VanderKam, James C. (1984). [Enoch and the Growth of an Apocalyptic Tradition](#). Catholic Biblical Association.

Conclusions About Genesis 5 and *The Sumerian King List*

It appears that the author of Genesis 5 is adapting a common Mesopotamian tradition about the 10 generations from the origins of kingship to the flood. At each step, the story launches an implicit critique of Babylon's claim to divine origins and offers an alternative story instead.

The gods of Babylon did not originate humanity or kingship. Rather, Yahweh, the God of Israel, created “humanity” (*adam*) as male and female in God's image. All humanity was made to rule. The fantastically long reigns of the Sumerian kings were literary images of their divine nature and rule. In contrast, the long lives of the patriarchs in Genesis 5 are all ended by death. This is part of a strategy showing that the loss of Eden and the increasing distance and alienation from the creator results in the diminishment of life. The seventh king, Enmeduranki, was elevated to the realm of the gods, where he became the source of secret divine knowledge given to the elite Babylonian diviners. In contrast, the seventh patriarch of Genesis 5, Enoch, is unique for his piety and communion with God, which results in his evasion of death and the gift of eternal life in Eden.

Genesis 5 is an Israelite version of the concepts being expressed in *The Sumerian King List* that claimed divine authority for Babylon's kings. The biblical author subverts those claims and offers a revisionist version, which places Israel's origins within these royal-priestly patriarchs, whose stories foreshadow the unique role that Israel will play among the nations later on in the story.

- The king and high priest will become “new Adams,” and they will restore Eden through their royal and priestly ministries.
- The priests will embody a “new Enoch,” and they will “walk with God” in the temple on behalf of Israel and open the way to eternal life in the holy of holies.
- Moses, the priests, and David will embody “new Noahs,” and they will call out to God in the midst of divine judgment and be delivered so that they can offer intercession on behalf of others.

Adam, Seth, and the Image of God

In Genesis 5:1-3, we are shown that the promised line of the seed will be carried on through Seth, Adam and Eve's third son.

Genesis 5:1-3 ESV*

¹ This is the scroll of the generations of ‘adam: In the day when God created ‘adam, **in the likeness of God** he made him, ² male and female he created them, and he blessed them, and he named them ‘adam in the day when they were created. ³ And Adam had lived one hundred and thirty years, and he became the father of a son **in his own likeness, according to his image**, and named him Seth.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Notice that ‘adam’s relationship to God is described as “image and likeness,” and this recalls all of the meaning and significance of [Genesis 1:26-28](#). Now, here in Genesis 5:1-3, Seth is described as his father’s image and likeness, on analogy to Adam’s relationship to God. The analogy illuminates two significant points for the rest of the biblical story.

Son of God = Image of God

If Seth is the “son of Adam” and can be called the image of Adam, then ‘adam too can be thought of as the “son of God,” which becomes a synonym for “image of God.”

Flash Forward: Notice that Luke’s genealogy of Jesus is constructed on this very conviction, tracing Jesus as the “son of God” all the way back to Adam as a “son of God” ([Luke 3:23-38](#)).

This set of ideas in Genesis 1-5 formed the template for later narratives in the Hebrew Bible that depict certain human rulers as “new Adams,” who are given a chance to be the “image of God” and rule the world on God’s behalf, overcoming the forces of animal-like chaos in the world.

The Unique Role of Enoch in Genesis 5

Enoch lives the shortest time span of all 10 patriarchs in Genesis 5—in fact, he is placed between the two longest-living figures in the genealogy, Jared and Methuselah.

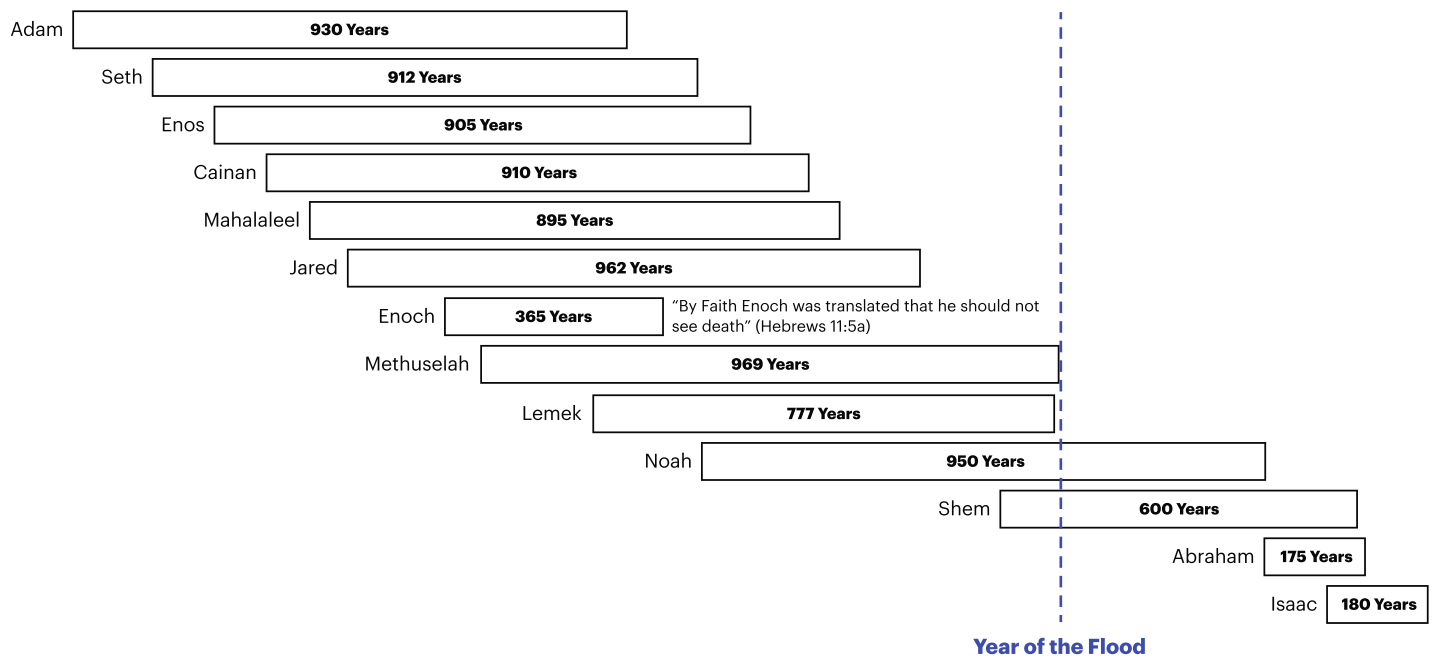
Verse	Person	Time
Gen 5:3	Adam	130 + 800 = 930
Gen 5:6	Seth	105 + 807 = 912
Gen 5:9	Enosh	90 + 815 = 905
Gen 5:12	Kenan	70 + 840 = 910

The Unique Role of Enoch in Genesis 5. Adapted from Hughes, Jeremy (2009). *Secrets of the Times: Myth and History in Biblical Chronology*. Sheffield Academic Press. By BibleProject for Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Verse	Person	Time
Gen 5:15	Mahalalel	$65 + 830 = 895$
Gen 5:18	Jared	$162 + 800 = 962$
Gen 5:21	Enoch	$65 + 300 = 365$
Gen 5:25	Methuselah	$187 + 782 = 969$
Gen 5:28	Lamech	$182 + 595 = 777$
Gen 5:32	Noah	500
Gen 7:6; 9:28	Age of Flood	$600 + 350 = 950$
<i>The Unique Role of Enoch in Genesis 5.</i> Adapted from Hughes, Jeremy (2009). <i>Secrets of the Times: Myth and History in Biblical Chronology</i> . Sheffield Academic Press. By BibleProject for Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).		

If we follow the numbers of the years for each of the patriarchs and notice when he had children, a fascinating fact becomes clear.

All of the patriarchs who came before Enoch were still alive when he was born, and Enoch was born 622 years after Adam and Eve's creation according to the Masoretic Hebrew chronology in Genesis 5. This means that among all of the patriarchs, including Adam, Enoch is singled out as the one who "walked with God" in a unique way. There is something superior about Enoch and his relationship to God that is, apparently, not true of his ancestors.



Overlap of the Lifespans of the Patriarchs. Created by Tim Mackie adapted from viz.bible for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

In Genesis 5:18-27, Enoch's story is modeled after all the others but differs at two strategic points.

Jared	Enoch	Methuselah
Gen 5:18 and Jared lived one hundred and sixty-two years,	Gen 5:21 and Enoch lived sixty-five years,	Gen 5:25 and Methuselah lived one hundred and eighty-seven years,
and became the father of Enoch.	and became the father of Methuselah.	and became the father of Lamech.
Gen 5:19 and Jared lived eight hundred years after he became the father of Enoch,	Gen 5:22 and Enoch walked with God three hundred years after he became the father of Methuselah,	Gen 5:26 Then Methuselah lived seven hundred and eighty-two years after he became the father of Lamech,
and he had sons and daughters.	and he had sons and daughters.	and he had sons and daughters.
Gen 5:20 and all the days of Jared were nine hundred and sixty-two years,	Gen 5:23 and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years.	Gen 5:27 So all the days of Methuselah were nine hundred and sixty-nine years,
<i>How Enoch Breaks the Pattern.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).		

Jared	Enoch	Methuselah
and he died .	Gen 5:24 and Enoch walked with God ; and he was no more , for God took him.	and he died .
<i>How Enoch Breaks the Pattern.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).		

- Notice how Jared and Methuselah’s “living” is in parallel with Enoch’s “walking with God.” This sets up an analogy between life and union with God—walking with God is true life.
- Notice also that Jared and Methuselah’s “death” is contrasted with Enoch’s “was not, for God took him.” If one’s life is defined by a close union with the author of life, then Enoch’s “being taken” is not death but transformation into a new mode of existence.
- Notice also the double repetition of the phrase “Enoch walked with God.” The first statement in 5:22 makes clear that this was his pattern of life for all 300 years, while the second statement in 5:24 implies that it was this special relationship with God that was connected to his “departure.”

Why Enoch, the Seventh from Adam?

- In Hebrew, “*enoch*” (חֲנוּךְ) means “dedicated” (used as a verb in [Deuteronomy 20:5](#) and [1 Kings 8:63](#), both about “dedicating” a house or temple).
- Enoch’s total age surely has symbolic significance: 365 years is the same as a solar calendar year.
- Enoch’s piety is linked to that of Adam and Eve’s in the garden of Eden and sets a pattern for later characters to attain.

Genesis 3:6, 8 Instructor's Translation

And [Eve] **took** (לָקַח) from its fruit and she ate ... And [Adam and Eve] heard the voice of Yahweh **walking** (מִתְהַלֵּךְ) in the garden.

Genesis 5:22, 25 Instructor's Translation

And Enoch **walked** (וַיִּתְחַלֵּךְ) with the-*elohim* ... And Enoch **walked** (וַיִּתְהַלֵּךְ) with the-*elohim*, and he was not, because *Elohim* **took** (לָקַח) him.”

Enoch’s way of life embodies the communion with God that Adam and Eve experienced and forfeited in the garden. Notice also the inversion of “taking.” Adam and Eve’s “taking” results in the loss of walking with God, while Enoch’s walking with God results in his being “taken.”

What Does It Mean to “Walk with God”?

This phrase is used of Noah in Genesis 6:8-9. And in 1 Samuel 25:15-16, the phrase is used to refer to friendly and close contact between people.

Genesis 6:8-9 NIV

⁸ But Noah found favor in the eyes of the Lord. ⁹ These are the records of the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous man, blameless in his time; Noah **walked with God**.

1 Samuel 25:14-16 NASB

¹⁴ But one of the young men told Abigail, Nabal's wife, saying, "Behold, David sent messengers from the wilderness to greet our master, and he scorned them. ¹⁵ Yet the men were very good to us, and we were not insulted, nor did we miss anything as long as we **walked with them**, while we were in the fields. ¹⁶ They were a wall to us both by night and by day, all the time we were with them tending the sheep."

"[T]he meaning of the phrase ... is obvious from 1 Samuel 25:15-16, where it describes friendly everyday conduct with regard to one's neighbors. The [author of Genesis 5] understood the words in the sense that Enoch stood in a direct and immediate relationship to God ... and so was entrusted with God's plans and intentions. This is the starting point for the significance that the figure of Enoch had in a tradition that began early and reached its fullness only in the Apocalyptic literature."

Westermann, Claus (1990). [*Genesis 1-11: Continental Commentaries*](#). Fortress Press.

"With Elohim"

Although it is not reflected in English, the word *elohim* in 5:22 and 5:24 has the definite article "the" in front of it (האלהים). The phrase "the *elohim*" can be used to refer to the single deity Yahweh, but it can also be a way of referring to spiritual beings, members of the divine council, or angels (Ps. 8:6; 82:1; 97:7; 138:1).

Notice also that in the phrase "for God took him," the word *elohim* does not have the definite article (כי לקח אתו אלהים). In other words, Enoch walks with the *elohim*, and so *Elohim* takes him.

This distinction seems like a meaningful one: Enoch's life was marked by friendly and intimate relations with the beings of the spiritual realm (the *elohim*), and so the chief *Elohim* (named Yahweh later in the story) takes him.

This was how the story was universally understood in ancient Judaism (see 1 Enoch, or 2 Enoch).

"And he walked with the *elohim*, and he was not, because God took him."

In the middle of a genealogy that focuses on death as the sad curtain-closer on God's blessing for life, Enoch's evasion of death in the seventh generation sticks out. He is marked as the seventh (i.e. complete) human whose allegiance and union with God results in eternal life.

The word "took" (לקח) is a reference back to Genesis 2:15, where God "took" the human he had created and "rested" (wordplay on Noah's name: וינחהו) him in the garden. Enoch is set in analogy to the human of Genesis 2, that is, Enoch is transferred to the garden of Eden, the realm of eternal life. This is how the earliest interpretation of the Enoch story goes, preserved in 1 Enoch chapters 24-32, in which Enoch is taken up in the Spirit and tours the cosmos until he arrives in Eden, the mountain of God.

Notice that the phrase is repeated in 5:22 and also in 5:24, which speaks of his "removal." This indicates that Enoch had close relationships with the *elohim* during his 365 years and presumably after his relocation to another realm.

In a later story modeled after Enoch's divine disappearance, Elijah's departure happens in a similar way and with similar vocabulary.

2 Kings 2:9-11 NASB

⁹ When they had crossed over, Elijah said to Elisha, "Ask what I shall do for you before **I am taken** from you." And Elisha said, "Please, let a double portion of your spirit be upon me." ¹⁰ He said, "You have asked a hard thing. Nevertheless, if you see me when **I am taken** from you, it shall be so for you; but if not, it shall not be so." ¹¹ As they were going along and talking, behold, there appeared a chariot of fire and horses of fire, which separated the two of them. And **Elijah went up in a storm to the heavens**.

The rainbow is a sign of God's judgment and rescue.

Psalms 49:15 KJV*

But God will redeem my soul from the power of the grave, for **he will take me**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The parallels between Adam and Enoch's being "taken" to Eden where they "walk with God" and the later design pattern of Elijah's departure suggest that Enoch is "taken" to Eden, the cosmic mountain in the skies. This is the primary image of "the heavens," where God's space and human space are one. This is how Enoch is portrayed in Jewish literature outside the Hebrew Bible (see 1 Enoch 14, 71; 2 Enoch).

"The passage, to be sure, gives the impression of being only a brief reference to a much more extensive tradition; it is an open question, therefore, whether much of the apocalyptic Enoch tradition is not really very old and precedes in time (not follows) the Priestly narrative."

von Rad, Gerhard; Trans: Marks, John H (1973). [*Genesis: A Commentary, Revised Edition*](#). John Knox Press.

Noah As the Promised "Comforter" of Humanity in Genesis 5

Lemek's anticipation of a future descendant in Genesis 5:29 who will bring an end to the curse picks up the macro theme of humanity's exile from Eden and the curse of death and the promise of a coming "seed" who will overcome the snake and its work.

Every line of Lemek's words has significant hyperlinks back to various texts in Genesis 1-3:

Genesis 5:29 NASB*

And he called his name "**Noah** (נח)," saying, "This one will give us **comfort** (נחם) from our work (מעשה) and from the **painful toil** (עצבון) of our hands, from the **ground** (האדמה) which the Lord has **cursed** (אררה)."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Noah's name is given significant theological meaning by means of wordplay.

"Noah" (נח) // "rest" (נוח) // "comfort" (נחם)

Noah's name is spelled like the word "rest," and it rhymes with the first two letters of the word "comfort."

Genesis 2:15 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh *Elohim* took the human and he **rested him** (וינחהו) in the garden of Eden, to work it (עבד) and to keep it.

Genesis 3:17, 19 Instructor's Translation

Cursed is the **ground** (ארורה האדמה) because of you, with **painful toil** (עצבון) you will from it ...until you return to the **ground** (האדמה), for from it you were taken ...

Genesis 3:23 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh *Elohim* sent him out from the garden of Eden to work (עבד) the **ground** (האדמה) from which he was taken ...

By means of this association, Noah's role in the story is previewed and given a theological interpretation. His obedient actions and his role as the surviving remnant in the generation of the flood are the ways that God is bringing rest and comfort to his world.

- **Rest (נוח)** is a major theological theme in the TaNaK, as it is often used to describe the restoration of Eden conditions on Earth as in Heaven. When God brings rest, it involves restoring a realm of order and sacred space where God can dwell with his people (Deut. 3:20; 12:10; Josh. 1:13; 21:44; 2 Sam. 7:1-11; 1 Kings 5:18).
- **Comfort (נחם)** is a major theme in the Prophets, especially Isaiah, and it describes the era of restoration when the failure of God's people is forgiven, their exile is over, and God renews the covenant with them in a restored Eden.

All of this points forward to Noah's crucial act of worship and obedience as he emerges from the ark in Genesis 8:20-22. In the narrative arc of Genesis 2-9, Noah is placed before the reader as an image of the promised seed of Genesis 3:15.

He is the righteous seed who passes the test through obedience to God's will and survives as a remnant through the waters of death to offer a precious sacrifice. This qualifies him to become the new humanity at the helm of a renewed creation that lives in a new covenant relationship with its creator. This narrative forms the thematic template for every single story to follow in the rest of the Hebrew Bible.

The Abraham Story

- Called out of Ur of the Chaldeans
- Given the promise of blessing and for all nations
- Fails many of his tests
- Passes the ultimate test by offering a sacrifice
- His sacrifice releases God's covenant blessing to all nations

The Moses Story

- Rescued in an "ark" through the waters of death

- Leads Israel to offer the Passover lamb
- God leads all the people through the waters to dry land
- Mediates a covenant with Israel to be priests for the nations
- Israel fails its test, but Moses offers himself as a sacrifice
- God comes to take up residence with his people in a micro-Eden

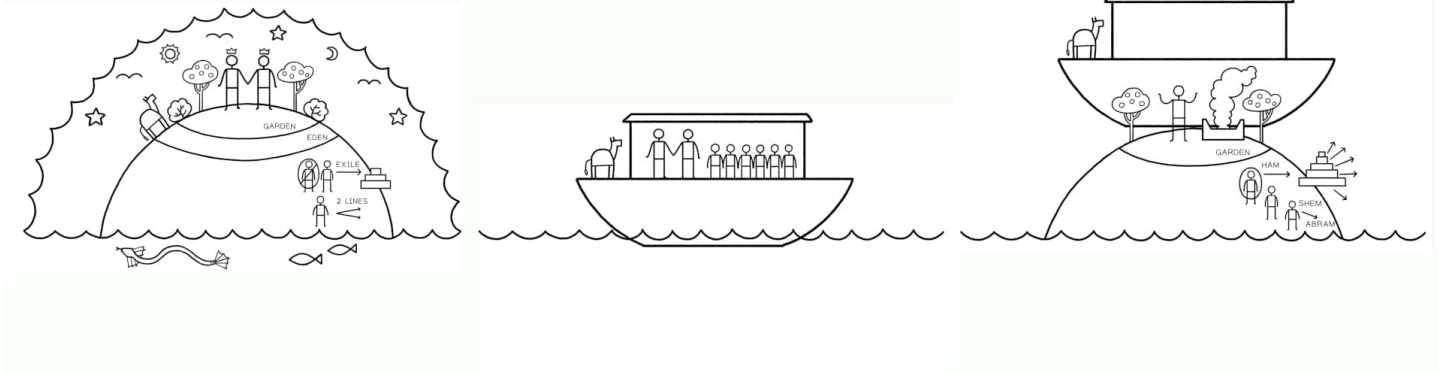
The Story of Judah and Exile

- Joshua leads the people to subdue the land of rest
- The people are given rest in the land
- The Israelites fail their many tests in the land and are exiled
- An obedient remnant survives exile and receives a message of comfort and restoration
- Restoration comes through the obedient self-sacrifice of the servant
- The servant's obedience unto death released blessing and new covenant to the nations

The Story of Jesus

- A new Joshua who will lead Israel into the new creation
- Jesus warns of a great flood of divine justice that is coming to Israel
- Jesus offers himself as a sacrifice, suffering the flood of exile and death
- Jesus' obedience unto death leads to resurrection life and releases blessing and a new covenant for all nations

Illustration: Preview of the Biblical Story Through Adam to Noah



Preview of the Biblical Story Through Adam to Noah. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Reflection Question

What is the difference between Enmeduranki, a hero of the Sumarian King List, and Enoch, the corresponding character in the Genesis 5 genealogy?



Module 6: Engaging with Genesis 2-5 Today

SESSIONS 30-32

Evaluate a few of the common questions modern readers have when they come to these stories and learn helpful perspectives that guide these inquiries.